



THE LANDSCAPING at the Pasadena facility was burning Jan. 7 when Jim Benesh arrived. The building eventually was destroyed too. ALLEN J. SCHABEN Los Angeles Times

She was left in senior facility as fire raged

Son raced to rescue Dorothy Benesh, 97, during Eaton blaze, found her alone. Advocates call for tougher state rules.

BY GRACE TOOHEY

Dorothy Benesh was waiting in her room for almost two hours as a fire alarm echoed through her assisted living facility. The 97-year-old had moved into the Terraces at Park Marino just months earlier and was told that if the alarm ever sounded, she should stay in her room until someone came to help. But that night — as the deadly Eaton fire exploded from a canyon just north of the Pasadena care facility — nobody came.



JIM BENESH BENESH took mother Dorothy to his home. The senior facility's CEO says firefighters told staff the building was cleared.

When her son Jim Benesh called to check on her, he was shocked to learn she was still in her room. He jumped in his car and sped to the nursing home, where he found her in an empty building. "There she was sitting on her couch — with the fire outside her window," he said. "It's unbelievable." As the Los Angeles County Board of Supervisors and local members of Congress direct separate investigations into electronic alert failures and delayed evacuation orders in Altadena during the Jan. 7 firestorm, the California Department of Social Services has confirmed that it is investigating at least two instances in which elderly women appear to have been forgotten at senior care facilities during the Eaton fire, including Dorothy Benesh. At the same time, relatives and elder [See Seniors, A12]

Trump freeze caused 'panic' in state

Agencies, programs that rely on federal funding fear more devastating effects. BY KEVIN RECTOR

Maricela Ramirez was at an education conference in Washington, D.C., at the end of January when she and other attendees heard the startling news: Federal funding for Head Start programs, which provide early-learning and nutritional support for low-income children nationwide, had been frozen. Ramirez, chief education officer for the Los Angeles County Office of Education, quickly contacted colleagues and realized it was true. They had tried to make a routine withdrawal of millions of dollars in funding the day prior, but it hadn't arrived overnight as expected. Ramirez recalled the "stress and panic" that quickly began to set in, both in her office and among the conference attendees all around her. "Our team had to assess whether LACOE would have to shut down its programs and to determine where LACOE could find funding to pay its employees if the system continued to be down," Ramirez recently wrote in a legal filing. Pauses in federal funding could disrupt mental health services, counseling, health screening and nutritional support for up to 8,000 children, she added. Ramirez's account of the fallout and ongoing fear caused by the Trump administration's sudden decision to halt billions of dollars in federal financial aid last month was one of more than 125 declarations of harm filed as part of a multistate lawsuit challenging the freeze in U.S. District Court. At least 16 declarations came from California. Together, the declarations paint a picture of alarm and chaos in the hours and days after the White House budget office announced the [See Funding, A6]

U.S., Russia discuss ending war on Ukraine

Talks do not include any representatives from Kyiv, a reversal of longtime policy.

BY TRACY WILKINSON

WASHINGTON — The United States formally brought Russia in from the cold Tuesday with high-level

talks aimed at ending Moscow's war with Ukraine and reestablishing long-frozen diplomatic and economic ties. A Trump administration team led by Secretary of State Marco Rubio sat down for four hours with senior representatives of Russian President Vladimir Putin in Riyadh, Saudi Arabia, in the first such meeting since Russia deepened an inva-

sion of Ukraine that launched the deadliest conflict in Europe since World War II. Neither Ukraine nor any European actor was invited to the talks, an omission that reversed U.S. policy that long insisted Kyiv be included in any negotiations to end the devastating war, which began three years ago. Until now, NATO and the U.S. were united in support-

ing Ukraine. "Today is the first step of a long and difficult journey, but an important one," Rubio told reporters after the meeting at a Saudi royal palace. "The work remains." A peace deal would have to be "fair, enduring, sustainable and acceptable," Rubio said, adding that he was convinced the Russians want to end the war. He also denied Europe and Ukraine

were being excluded, saying he and other U.S. officials were briefing other nations as the diplomatic process continues. Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelensky and Western officials dispute that idea, noting that Russia so far has given up nothing while Ukraine is being told to make concessions. In Tuesday's talks, the [See Ukraine, A4]

Bill targets skin care for minors

Proposed ban on sale of potent products to children comes amid a surge fueled by social media. BUSINESS, A8

Betts stepping it up at shortstop

After winter training with mentor, the Dodgers star's move back from the outfield looks smoother. SPORTS, B10

A big refresh for popular venue

The Shrine Auditorium gets modern upgrades in advance of its 100th anniversary. ENTERTAINMENT, E1

Weather Mostly sunny. L.A. Basin: 71/50. B6

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COLUMN ONE

A lasting impression of their Hollywood careers

Showbiz veterans find a creative outlet for their spicy stories in memoir writing group

BY DEBORAH NETBURN

S seated at a folding table in a large sun-filled room, Melody Sherwood adjusted the portable microphone stand and started to read. "One of Cary Grant's favorite things to do was to tell stories," she began in a voice like that of an old-fashioned schoolteacher. "He had an abundant supply. One of my favorite things to do was listen to him tell them." Sherwood, a close friend of Grant who spent 30 years working as Lew Wasserman's executive assistant at Universal, went on to relay an only-in-Hollywood tale involving Grant's first time entertaining troops overseas, a practical joke by actor David Niven and why for the last 50 years she's had a vanity license plate with the letters



AL SEIB For The Times MELODY Sherwood addresses a Grey Quill Society meeting at the Motion Picture & Television Fund's Woodland Hills campus.

GAFY on it, an acronym for "Go and F— Yourself." It was a surprisingly spicy story for a seemingly buttoned-up 81-year-old woman, but bold-faced names and the occasional curse word are par for the course at the Grey Quill Society, a weekly memoir writing group for residents of the Motion Picture & Television Fund's Woodland Hills community for aging entertainment professionals. That morning, the group had already heard from a retired character actor about the time Doris Day persuaded her to help rescue a starving dog in Beverly Hills. A former flamenco dancer shared a tale about her nerve-racking stint working for Morris "Moishe" Levy, a music business executive with reported mob ties. Bob Beitcher, president and chief executive of the Motion Pic- [See Quill, A9]



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